

**TRICYCLE FARE REGULATION ENFORCEMENT AND PASSENGER
PROTECTION IN STA. CRUZ, LAGUNA**

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Chapter 1

THE PROBLEM AND ITS BACKGROUND

Introduction

In a community where tricycles are part of everyday transportation, the fare paid by a passenger may seem like a simple transaction, but it is also connected to the rules established by local authorities. The Independent Variable of this study is Local Government Unit (LGU) Enforcement and Regulation, which refers to the actions taken by the local government to establish, communicate, monitor, and enforce tricycle fare regulations. A visible fare matrix can serve as a point of reference for both drivers and passengers, allowing passengers to recognize the authorized amount they are expected to pay. Meanwhile, regulatory monitoring represents the efforts of authorities to check whether tricycle operators are following the prescribed rules. Therefore, LGU enforcement is not only about creating regulations but also about making sure that these regulations are visible, understandable, and consistently applied in actual transportation situations.

The Dependent Variable of the study is Passenger Protection, which focuses on how well passengers are protected through fair and properly regulated tricycle fare practices. Rather than viewing passengers only as people who pay for transportation, this study considers them as individuals who should be able to understand the fare they are being charged and have confidence that established regulations are being followed. Passenger protection will be examined through fairness of fares and satisfaction with

regulatory response. Fairness of fares refers to the passengers' perception of whether the amount they pay is reasonable and consistent with the authorized fare. On the other hand, satisfaction with regulatory response considers whether passengers feel that their concerns regarding fare-related issues are properly recognized and addressed by the responsible authorities. These indicators make passenger protection more than simply avoiding overcharging; it also involves transparency, accountability, and the passengers' sense that there is a system capable of responding when transportation rules are not followed.

though tricycles provide accessible transportation within Sta. Cruz, Laguna, the experience of riding one does not always end with simply reaching a destination. Existing discussions about tricycle transportation commonly focus on fares, commuting experiences, or the operation of public transportation, but fewer studies examine how local enforcement practices are connected specifically to passengers' perception of protection, particularly in the context of Sta. Cruz, Laguna. This creates a local research gap because the presence of a regulation does not automatically show whether passengers recognize it, experience its implementation, or feel protected by it. Examining this gap can provide a clearer picture of whether fare regulation functions as an actual form of passenger protection in the community.

This study aims to examine the relationship between Tricycle Fare Regulation Enforcement and Passenger Protection in Sta. Cruz, Laguna. Specifically, it seeks to determine how passengers perceive LGU enforcement through the presence of fare matrix displays and regulatory monitoring, and how these relate to fare fairness and satisfaction with regulatory responses.

The study also highlights the experiences of passengers, which may sometimes be overlooked in discussions about transportation regulations. Ultimately, the findings may help local authorities improve fare regulation and enforcement to create a more transparent, fair, responsive, and passenger-protective transportation system.

Background of the Study

Public transportation plays a vital role in the daily lives of Filipinos, especially in municipalities like Sta. Cruz, Laguna where tricycles serve as the primary mode of short-distance travel. Tricycles provide accessible and affordable transport for students, workers, and residents going to markets, schools, and government offices. However, issues regarding fare collection, lack of regulation, and passenger complaints continue to persist. These problems not only affect the convenience of commuters but also reduce their confidence in the fairness of local transport services.

Tricycle Fare Regulation refers to the implementation of laws and ordinances by the Local Government Unit to set and enforce standardized fares. According to the Local Government Code of 1991 (RA 7160), the Sangguniang Bayan has the power to regulate fares of tricycles operating within its jurisdiction to protect commuters from overcharging (Congress of the Philippines, 1991). This law gives LGUs the responsibility to ensure that fare rates are reasonable, properly posted, and followed by all operators. Despite this mandate, studies show that enforcement remains weak in many areas.

Several studies have pointed out the challenges in enforcing tricycle fare ordinances. A study by Lao (2013) found that many tricycle drivers do not follow

the official fare matrix due to lack of monitoring, poor visibility of fare guides, and weak apprehension by authorities. The study also noted that passengers are often hesitant to report violations because there is no clear complaint mechanism. Similarly, Reyes and Santos (2010) stated that inconsistent enforcement leads to overcharging, bargaining, and disputes between drivers and passengers, which affects public trust in local transport regulation.

Passenger protection involves ensuring that commuters are charged the correct fare, treated fairly, and have access to avenues for complaints. Bautista (2008) emphasized that passenger rights are often neglected in informal transport systems because passengers lack awareness of existing ordinances. The study recommended that LGUs should intensify information campaigns and install visible fare matrices in terminals. De Guzman (2011) also highlighted that without proper enforcement, passengers — especially students and senior citizens — become vulnerable to exploitation. The absence of a quick and accessible grievance system makes it difficult for commuters to seek redress. Therefore, this study aims to determine the current level of Tricycle Fare Regulation Enforcement and Passenger Protection in Sta. Cruz, Laguna. The findings may help the LGU, TODA, and commuters in creating better policies and mechanisms to ensure fair fares and passenger welfare.

Theoretical Framework

This study is anchored on Deterrence Theory, which suggests that individuals are more likely to comply with laws and regulations when violations are likely to be detected and punished (Gibbs, 1975). Effective enforcement of tricycle fare regulations encourages drivers and operators to follow the

approved fare matrix because the possibility of penalties increases compliance.

The study is also supported by Consumer Protection Theory, which emphasizes that consumers have the right to fair treatment, accurate information, and protection from unfair business practices (Kennedy, 1962). In public transportation, passengers are entitled to transparent and reasonable fares as provided by existing local regulations.

These theories explain that consistent enforcement of fare regulations strengthens compliance among tricycle drivers while promoting passenger welfare, transparency, and accountability in local transportation services. The Local Government Code and DOTC/LTO guidelines authorize local governments to regulate tricycle operations and establish fare rates for the protection of both operators and passengers.

Conceptual Framework

The conceptual framework of the study consists of one independent variable and one dependent variable. The independent variable is LGU Enforcement and Regulation, measured in terms of the presence of fare matrix displays and regulatory monitoring.

The dependent variable is Passenger Protection, which includes fairness of fares and satisfaction with the regulatory response.

The framework illustrates how LGU enforcement and regulation may affect passenger protection, as presented in the research paradigm. It shows

that effective enforcement and regulation may encourage fair fares and improve passengers' satisfaction with the LGU's response.

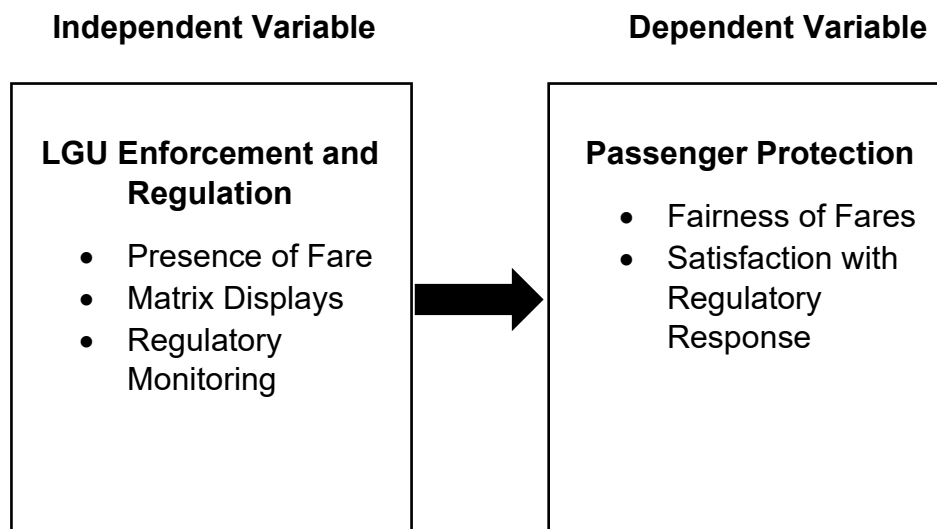


Figure 1. Research Paradigm3Z

Statement of the Problem

The purpose of the study is to determine the effect of LGU Enforcement and Regulations on Passenger Protection in tricycle fare regulation in Sta. Cruz, Laguna.

Specifically, this study sought to answer the following questions:

1. What is the level of LGU Enforcement and Regulations in Sta. Cruz, Laguna in terms of:

- 1.1 Presence of Fare Matrix

- 1.2 Displays of Regulatory Monitoring

2. What is the level of Passenger Protection in Sta. Cruz, Laguna in terms of:

- 2.1 Fairness of Fares

- 2.2 Satisfaction with Regulatory Response

3. Is there a significant effect of LGU Enforcement and Regulations on the Fairness of Fares for tricycle passengers in Sta. Cruz, Laguna?

Research Hypothesis

This study is guided by the following null hypothesis, which will be tested to determine whether Tricycle Fare Regulation Enforcement is significant related to Passenger in Sta. Cruz, Laguna.

H_0 : There is no significant relationship between tricycle fare regulation enforcement and passenger protection in Sta. Cruz, Laguna

Significance of the Study

The findings of the study may provide information and data significant to the following:

Passengers. The study may help passengers to better understand their rights regarding tricycle fare regulations. It may also encourage them to be more aware of the official fare matrix and report cases of fare overcharging.

Tricycle Drivers. The study may help drivers recognize the importance of following official fare regulations. It may encourage them to practice fair and lawful fare collection, promoting trust and good relationships with passengers.

Local Government Unit (LGU). The findings may provide the LGU with information about the effectiveness of its fare regulation enforcement. It may serve as a basis for improving monitoring, implementing stricter enforcement, and strengthening passenger protection programs.

Future Researchers. The findings of this study may serve as a reference for future researchers who wish to conduct similar studies on tricycle fare regulation, passenger protection, and public transportation services. It may also provide a foundation for further research in this field.

Scope and Limitation

This study focuses on the enforcement of tricycle fare regulations and passenger protection in Sta. Cruz, Laguna. It will involve 50 regular tricycle passengers who have used tricycle services within Santa Cruz. The study will assess passengers' experiences regarding the implementation of the approved fare, fare transparency, compliance of drivers, and the protection and fair treatment received by passengers. Data will be collected through a structured survey questionnaire during the period of the study.

The respondents of the study will consist of regular tricycle passengers and, when applicable, selected tricycle drivers or transport officials within Sta. Cruz, Laguna. Data will be gathered using a structured survey questionnaire and analyzed to describe the relationship between fare regulation enforcement and passenger protection.

The study is limited to tricycle passengers within Sta. Cruz, Laguna and does not include jeepneys, buses, taxis, private vehicles, or other transportation services. Tricycle drivers and local transportation officials will not be included as respondents. The study will also rely on the participants' personal experiences and perceptions, which may differ from actual enforcement records. Changes in fare rates, local ordinances, fuel prices, and other transportation conditions during or after the data-gathering period are beyond the scope of the study. Therefore, the findings will apply specifically to the selected respondents and may not represent all tricycle passengers in Laguna.

Definition of Terms

The following terms are defined according to their use in the study to provide clarity and ensure a better understanding of the key concepts and variables.

LGU Enforcement. Refers to the actions and policies implemented by the Local Government Unit to ensure that tricycle fare regulations are properly followed.

Fare Matrix Display. Refers to the visible posting of the official fare matrix inside or on tricycles to inform passengers of the authorized fares.

Regulatory Monitoring. Refers to the inspection and supervision conducted by the LGU or concerned authorities to ensure that tricycle drivers comply with fare regulations.

Passenger Protection. Refers to the measures that protect passengers from unfair fare practices and ensure their rights as commuters are respected.

Fairness of Fares. Refers to passengers perception that the fare they pay is reasonable, legal, and consistent with the official fare matrix.

Satisfaction with Regulatory Response. Refers to the level of satisfaction of passengers with the actions taken by the LGU in addressing complaints and enforcing tricycle fare regulations.